FESTIVE DINING GUIDE · NAVRATRI 2026

Navratri in Edinburgh 2026

Festive Dining Ideas at Kalpna



Nine nights of garba, family and festive vegetarian feasting on St Patrick Square

11 – 19 October 2026

Purely vegetarian since 1975

2–3 St Patrick Square, Edinburgh

Autumn in Edinburgh has its own rhythm. The evenings draw in, Arthur's Seat catches golden light through the afternoon, and the city grows a little more still. For many Hindu families across Scotland, autumn also brings Navratri: nine nights of prayer, music, garba and gatherings with the people who matter most.

Navratri is a festival of togetherness, and so much of that togetherness happens around the table. Whether you are heading out after an evening of dandiya, catching up with friends during the festival week or planning a family meal to mark Dussehra, Kalpna Restaurant Edinburgh on St Patrick Square is a warm, purely vegetarian place to celebrate Navratri 2026.

What Navratri Celebrates

Navratri means "nine nights" in Sanskrit. Over these nights, devotees honour the goddess Durga in her many forms, with each day linked to a different aspect of her energy. The festival ends with Vijayadashami, also known as Dussehra, which marks the triumph of good over evil.

Sharad Navratri, the autumn festival, is the most widely observed. Communities gather for garba and dandiya raas, the whirling folk dances of Gujarat, families dress in bright colours, and evenings stretch late into the night. It is one of the most joyful times of the Hindu calendar.

When Is Navratri 2026?

Sharad Navratri follows the lunar calendar, so the dates move each year. Navratri 2026 begins on Sunday 11 October and runs for nine nights to Monday 19 October, with Dussehra 2026 on Tuesday 20 October.

NAVRATRI 2026 AT A GLANCE

Night 1 Sun 11 Oct	**Night 2** Mon 12 Oct	**Night 3** Tue 13 Oct	**Night 4** Wed 14 Oct	**Night 5** Thu 15 Oct
Night 6 Fri 16 Oct	**Night 7** Sat 17 Oct	**Night 8** Sun 18 Oct	**Night 9** Mon 19 Oct	**Dussehra** Tue 20 Oct

Edinburgh's Hindu and Gujarati community organises garba nights and cultural gatherings across the festival, and local temples hold aarti and prayers. With so much happening, the festival week is a natural time to plan a Navratri dinner out with family and friends.

Why Kalpna Suits a Navratri Celebration

Kalpna is a family-run **vegetarian Indian restaurant in Edinburgh**, established in 1975 and one of the longest-running vegetarian Indian restaurants in Scotland. It opened when a fully vegetarian Indian restaurant was still unusual in the UK, and it has kept that focus ever since.

That matters during a religious festival. Every dish comes from a purely vegetarian kitchen, so families can order freely without asking whether anything crossed paths with meat, fish or eggs. The menu draws on Punjabi, Kashmiri, Mughlai and South Indian cooking, which means there is usually something familiar for every generation at the table.

It remains a popular choice among Indian restaurants in Edinburgh for family celebrations, and it is easy to reach. It sits in Newington, a short walk from the University of Edinburgh's central campus, the Southside and the Old Town.

> *"The dances are joyful because they are danced in circles, and the meals are memorable because they are shared."*

Navratri Dining Ideas at Kalpna

The festive spirit of Navratri is about variety and sharing. Here are some ideas for building a celebratory Navratri dinner from the **Kalpna vegetarian menu**.

Start with Indian Street Food and Small Plates

Indian street food in Edinburgh doesn't get much more festive. Street-style bites are perfect for a lively table after an evening of garba. Samosa Chaat layers samosa with chickpeas, pomegranate, yoghurt and tangy chutneys. Vada Pav, the famous Mumbai street snack, brings a spiced potato fritter in a toasted pav. For something a little more refined, try the Dahi Kebab with sweet spices and crisp kataifi, or the Chukandari ki Tikki, a beetroot tikki with kasundi mustard and a date and tamarind reduction.

Order a few plates for the middle of the table and let everyone dig in. If you love these flavours, read more about **the story of Indian chaat** and why it is loved across India.

Rich Curries for a Festive Main Course

A Navratri dinner calls for something generous. Saam Savera, a spinach and paneer roulade in a rich Mughlai-style gravy, is a showpiece dish for a special night. Dum Aloo Kashmiri brings stuffed potatoes in a saffron tomato sauce with almonds, while Khubani Kofta pairs apricot koftas with a cashew gravy and a gentle date sweetness.

For classic North Indian comfort, Butter Paneer, Kadhai Paneer, Punjabi Chole and the slow-cooked Kalpna Dal Makhani never go out of fashion. Pair them with garlic naan, Peshawari naan or tandoori roti.

South Indian Favourites in Edinburgh

If your family celebrates Navratri the South Indian way, Kalpna's dosas are a natural choice. The Mysore Masala Dosa, Butter Masala Dosa and Palak Paneer Dosa all come with sambhar, chutneys and salad. For a lighter curry, the Ananas Moilee (pineapple in coconut milk with curry leaves) and Kumbh Coconut Curry go beautifully with coconut rice. Our guide to **South Indian vs North Indian vegetarian food** explains how the two styles differ.

A Navratri Thali for the Whole Table

A thali is one of the easiest ways to celebrate, especially when your group mixes first-timers and regulars. The Thaali Raj Bhog is a royal platter with starters, dal, four vegetable curries, rice, bread, raita, chutney and dessert. The smaller Kalpna Thaali offers a starter, two curries, rice, dal, bread, chutney, raita and dessert.

Both come in vegan versions too, which makes Kalpna a natural pick among vegan restaurants in Edinburgh and a mixed table much easier to coordinate. New to the format? Our guide to the **Indian thali** walks you through how to enjoy one.

Finish with Something Sweet

No festival meal is complete without dessert. Gulab Jamun in warm rose and cardamom syrup, saffron-scented Rice Kheer and Kesar Malai Pista Kulfi are all festive classics. The Coconut Halwa is a vegan option, and the Kalpna Mastani brings mango, chocolate, nuts and rose together for something a little different. Order two or three to share so everyone gets a taste.

Suggested Navratri Orders

For two after garba night

Samosa Chaat and Dahi Kebab to share, Saam Savera and a Mysore Masala Dosa, garlic naan, and Gulab Jamun to finish.

For a family of four to six

Three shared starters, two rich curries such as Butter Paneer and Dum Aloo Kashmiri, Kalpna Dal Makhani, a lighter South Indian dish like Ananas Moilee, two breads, coconut rice and two desserts.

For a mixed vegan and vegetarian table

Pakora and Gobi Manchurian to start, Punjabi Chole, Baingan Bharta and Kumbh Coconut Curry, Edamame Biryani, and Coconut Halwa for dessert, with a Vegan Thaali Raj Bhog for anyone who wants a bit of everything.

Lunch During Navratri Week

Not every celebration has to be an evening affair. Kalpna's Indian lunch buffet in Edinburgh runs from 12:00 to 14:30, making it an easy option for students between lectures, colleagues marking the festival together, or family visiting during the day. It is a relaxed way to enjoy a range of vegetarian Indian dishes without the evening rush.

Navratri Away From Home

For students and young professionals who moved to Edinburgh for university or work, Navratri can be one of the moments when home feels far away. A shared meal helps. Whether you gather with a few friends after evening prayers or bring family in for a sit-down dinner, the food is what carries the memory.

Kalpna's location close to the University of Edinburgh has made it a familiar stop for generations of students marking festivals away from home. Planning a bigger get-together with your society or friends? Our tips on **group dining in Edinburgh** will help.

Tips for Dining Out During Navratri

- **Book ahead,** especially for weekend evenings and Dussehra, when tables fill quickly
- **Plan around garba,** booking an earlier table before the dancing or a later one after
- **Mention dietary needs** across the table, including vegan guests and allergies
- **Share plates,** since the festive spirit is all about variety
- **Save room for dessert,** because sweets are part of every celebration

You can **book a table at Kalpna** online, or call 0131 667 9890 to speak to the team.

From Navratri to Diwali



Navratri is only the start of the festive season. Dussehra follows on 20 October, and Diwali arrives a few weeks later. Kalpna's special **Diwali menu in Edinburgh** runs from 6 to 15 November 2026, with a festive Diwali thali and a set course for two.

A Festival Best Shared

Navratri is about coming together. The dances are joyful because they are danced in circles, and the meals are memorable because they are shared. Edinburgh in autumn suits it perfectly. The city slows, the days shorten, and there is something right about gathering round a warm table when the wind picks up outside.

Frequently Asked Questions

When is Navratri 2026?

Sharad Navratri 2026 begins on Sunday 11 October and runs for nine nights to Monday 19 October, with Dussehra on Tuesday 20 October.

Where can I celebrate Navratri with a meal in Edinburgh?

Kalpna on St Patrick Square is a purely vegetarian Indian restaurant, family-run since 1975, and a popular choice for festival dinners with family and friends.

Is Kalpna fully vegetarian?

Yes. Everything Kalpna cooks is vegetarian, and many dishes are marked vegan on the menu.

Does Kalpna have a special Navratri fasting menu?

Kalpna doesn't run a dedicated vrat menu. It's a great choice for celebratory meals during the festival week, after garba, or to mark Dussehra with family.

What should I order for a Navratri dinner at Kalpna?

Mix shared starters like Samosa Chaat and Dahi Kebab with rich curries such as Saam Savera or Butter Paneer, a dosa or South Indian curry, breads, rice and a couple of desserts. A thali is a simple alternative if you'd prefer a single order.

Are there vegan options?

Yes. The menu includes vegan starters, curries, dosas, biryani and desserts, plus the Vegan Thaali Raj Bhog and Vegan Kalpna Thaali.

Does Kalpna serve lunch?

Yes. The lunch buffet runs from 12:00 to 14:30.

Do I need to book during Navratri?

Booking is recommended, especially for evenings, weekends and Dussehra.

Kalpna

Celebrate Navratri at Kalpna

Purely vegetarian Indian cooking in Edinburgh since 1975

Book Your Table

2–3 St Patrick Square, Edinburgh EH8 9EZ · 0131 667 9890 · kalpnarestaurant.co.uk